

CHAPTER 1 – THE BOX IN THE ATTIC

Washington, D.C. – Josva’s Townhouse, 11:17 PM

The rain had been falling for hours, a steady, relentless percussion against the slate roof that made the old townhouse feel like it was breathing. I stood in the narrow attic crawlspace, flashlight beam cutting through dust motes thick as ash, and tried to convince myself this was just another late-night ritual of a man who couldn’t sleep. My campaign schedule had been brutal—three fundraisers, two network interviews, one whispered meeting with party elders who wanted to know if I was “ready for the spotlight.” Ready. The word tasted like rust in my mouth.

I was forty-two, scarred from a decade of backroom deals and buried favors, yet somehow still climbing. Josva Alden, the independent senator from nowhere, the man with the quiet voice and the steel-gray eyes that made donors write checks and opponents check their exits. But tonight none of that mattered. Tonight I was just a man in sweat-dampened shirtsleeves, chasing a memory I couldn’t name.

The box had been waiting up here since I bought the place six years ago. Sealed with faded packing tape, addressed to me in handwriting I didn’t recognize. I’d shoved it into the far corner behind a stack of campaign plaques and forgotten it the way you forget a half-healed wound—

until tonight. Until the dream came again: flickering streetlights, the wet slap of rain on concrete, Sider's blood mixing with gutter water. His last words still echoed if I let them: *Remember the basement, J. We never really left.*

I dragged the box into the weak circle of my flashlight. It was heavier than I remembered. The cardboard had gone soft with age, corners chewed by something small and hungry. My gloved hands—always gloved now, ever since the Miami alley—trembled only slightly as I sliced the tape with a pocket knife. The sound was too loud in the quiet. Like skin parting.

Inside, nestled in yellowed tissue paper that smelled faintly of smoke and something sweeter, something wrong, lay the first artifact.

A Polaroid. Cracked down the middle, the plastic warped as if it had been held too close to a fire. I pulled it free and the beam caught the image: Sider and me, younger, thinner, standing in that Miami alley at 3 a.m. His arm was slung around my shoulders. We were both laughing at something off-camera, but the laughter didn't reach our eyes. Behind us, half-hidden in shadow, was a child-sized figure in a tattered yellow coat, face obscured. Its posture was wrong—too rigid, like a marionette with cut strings. I didn't remember anyone else being there that night. I blinked hard, but the figure stayed. My pulse kicked up a notch, steady and heavy behind my ribs.

Beneath the photo lay a brooch. Small, silver, shaped like a simple puppet silhouette—strings trailing from its limbs. The metal was tarnished except for one spot where something dark had dried in the crevices. Blood. Old blood. I knew the texture without touching it. I'd seen enough of it in my life. My stomach tightened, not with nausea but with a deeper, colder recognition. I turned the brooch over. On the back, etched in tiny letters:
Hollowbrook – Property of Subject T.

The name meant nothing. And yet my mouth went dry.

Next came a friendship bracelet. Cheap cotton threads in faded green, yellow, red, and purple, the kind kids make at summer camp. Three of the strands were stiff with old stains. I ran my thumb across them and felt the faint crust give way, like scabs. My mind supplied the image unbidden: small hands braiding these threads in the dark, whispering codes against concrete walls. I shook my head. I had never been to summer camp. I had never braided anything in my life.

And at the very bottom of the box, wrapped in a separate square of velvet the color of dried violets, rested an envelope. Yellowed. Wax seal cracked open like a broken promise. My own name was written across the front in the same elegant, looping script as the box label. Not my handwriting. Close—terrifyingly close—but the loops

were too tight, too desperate, as if the writer had been fighting to keep the pen steady.

I should have stopped there. Called Naomi. Called someone. Instead I carried the entire box downstairs to my study, rain still drumming overhead like impatient fingers. The house felt different now, heavier. Every creak of the floorboards sounded like someone shifting weight behind me.

I set the box on the mahogany desk beside the half-empty glass of bourbon I'd poured and forgotten. The lamp cast a warm circle of light, but the shadows at the edges of the room seemed to lean in, listening. I sat. The leather chair sighed beneath me. My reflection in the dark window looked like a stranger—eyes too wide, jaw clenched so tight the scar along my left cheek pulled white.

I picked up the Polaroid again. Studied the yellow-coated figure. The longer I stared, the more details emerged: the coat wasn't fabric. It was paper, layered and folded into crude puppet joints. The face—God, the face. A painted smile stretched ear to ear, but the eyes were black holes. Not shadows. Holes. As if someone had burned them out with a cigarette.

My breath hitched. I knew that smile. Not from any children's show I could name, but from somewhere deeper. Somewhere that smelled of bleach and wet stone and the faint, metallic tang of fear-sweat. Hollowbrook.

The word surfaced again, uninvited. I whispered it aloud just to hear how it tasted.

“Hollowbrook.”

The rain answered with a sudden gust that rattled the windowpane like it wanted inside. I set the photo down. My gloved fingers left faint prints on the glossy surface.

I wasn't supposed to remember. That was the deal I'd made with myself after Miami. Bury it. Build a new life. Run for office. Smile for the cameras. But the box had found me anyway. Someone—maybe the same person who'd sealed it years ago—wanted me to open old wounds.

I reached for the envelope. The wax flaked away like dead skin. Inside was a single sheet of stiff parchment. I unfolded it slowly, the way you might handle a sleeping snake.

The handwriting was identical to the address label. And this time there was a date at the top: *March 12, 2017. Two days before Sider died.*

The first line read:

If you're reading this, J, then the strings are already pulling again. They never cut us loose. They only lengthened the cord.

My mouth went dry. I kept reading, the words sinking into me like hooks.

I don't know how long I sat there. The bourbon grew warm. The rain kept falling. Somewhere in the distance a siren wailed once, then died. I folded the letter carefully, placed it back in the envelope, and rested both palms flat on the desk. My reflection stared back from the window, but now there was something else in the glass—faint, superimposed, like a double exposure.

A child's face. Yellow coat. Painted smile stretched too wide. Black holes where eyes should be.

It wasn't in the room. It couldn't be. But I felt it watching all the same.

I closed my eyes. Breathed in the scent of old blood and powdered sugar and something that might have been burning hair. When I opened them again the reflection was only me.

But the box was still open on my desk. The artifacts still lay there like evidence at a crime scene that had never been reported.

And for the first time in years, I felt the basement door inside my mind creak open, just a crack.

I stood up. Crossed to the window. Pressed my forehead to the cool glass and watched the rain streak down like tears I refused to shed.

Whatever was coming, it had already started.

I whispered to the empty room, voice low and steady, the way I used to talk to Sider when things got bad.

“I’m listening now.”

Outside, the storm answered with a roll of thunder that shook the house to its bones.

CHAPTER 2 – THE MEMORY CARVES DEEPER

Washington, D.C. – Josva's Townhouse, 11:41 PM

The letter trembled in my gloved hands like a living thing. I had only read the first few lines, but they had already burrowed under my skin. *If you're reading this, J, then the strings are already pulling again. They never cut us loose. They only lengthened the cord.* My study felt smaller now, the lamplight shrinking to a single harsh circle that left the corners thick with shadow. Rain still hammered the roof, but it sounded farther away, as if the house itself were pulling back from what was coming.

I told myself to stop. To seal the envelope, lock the box, pour another bourbon and pretend tomorrow's schedule mattered. Instead my eyes dragged down the page, the elegant loops of that almost-my handwriting pulling me deeper.

The letter continued:

We called ourselves the Shadow Puppets back then, four broken kids in Hollowbrook's sub-basement. No windows. No clocks. Just the drip of condensation on concrete and the radios they gave us like cruel jokes—tinny voices from a world we'd never touch again. They were taking even those away. So we made our choice.

My throat tightened. I knew what was coming before the words arrived, the way you know the shape of a scar before you touch it.

We used whatever we could steal. A shard of mirror glass for Elara. A sharpened bed spring for Pyra. Silas took a rusted nail. I—Thorne—used the edge of my own radio casing, filed against the floor until it could bite.

The room around me began to tilt. The scent of old blood on the brooch rose sharper now, mixing with the powdered-sugar rot from the tissue paper. I gripped the desk edge, but the wood felt wrong—cold, damp, like concrete.

And then the memory slammed into me, not as words on paper but as something physical, something that ripped open inside my own body.

I was there.

Not watching. *Being.*

The cell was smaller than any coffin. I—Josva, but not Josva, not yet—lay on my back on the freezing floor, shirt torn open, the faint static of the radio still crackling from its hiding place under the thin mattress. My ribs rose and fell too fast. The shard of glass in my right hand was slick already, though I hadn't cut yet. My left hand pressed against my bare stomach, feeling the warmth of skin I was about to destroy.

I pressed the edge just below my navel.

The first slice was almost gentle—a cold line that parted the skin with a soft, wet *schlick*, like scissors through wet silk. Then the pain bloomed, bright and immediate, a white-hot wire threading straight through my gut. Blood welled up instantly, warm and thick, spilling over my fingers in pulsing sheets. It smelled of copper and salt and something faintly sour underneath. I bit down on the rag in my mouth so hard my molars ached, but a low animal sound still escaped.

I had to go deeper.

I angled the glass and pushed. Skin gave way to the yellow-white layer of fat, then the tougher fascia beneath. Each millimeter felt like teeth chewing inward. Blood poured faster now, hot rivers running down my sides to pool beneath my back, soaking into the thin mattress until I could feel the chill of the concrete seeping through. My vision tunneled, black spots blooming at the edges.

Deeper still.

The blade found muscle. I gasped around the rag as the abdominal wall split with a wet tearing sound I felt more than heard. My own intestines brushed against the glass—slick, ropey, alive. They shifted under my probing fingers like startled snakes, warm and glistening, pulsing with my frantic heartbeat. I gagged at the smell: blood, bile, the

faint metallic tang of exposed organs. One coil slipped out over the wound's edge, shiny and purple-red in the dim emergency bulb. I shoved it back in with trembling, blood-slick hands, the surface of it so fragile I was terrified it would rupture under my palm.

The radio waited on the floor beside me—small, black, heavier than it had any right to be. Its antenna was already bent into a crude hook. I had to make space.

I reached in.

My fingers slid between slick loops of intestine, the heat of my own body shocking. They were warmer than I expected, almost feverish, and they moved against my touch like they were trying to push me out. I felt the radio's casing scrape against the inside of my abdominal wall—cold metal against raw meat—and a fresh wave of agony exploded upward. Something tore. A thin, high sound left my throat despite the rag. Blood bubbled up around my wrist where it disappeared inside myself, thick and dark now, almost black in the low light.

I forced the radio deeper.

Wires caught on something soft and gave way with a sickening *pop*. Acid from my stomach leaked around the intrusion, burning like liquid fire along every nerve. I could feel the device settling against my spine, its edges pressing into organs that were never meant to be touched.

Every breath now sent fresh pain lancing through me. Every heartbeat pushed more blood out of the wound in rhythmic surges that soaked my pants and puddled beneath my hips.

I was crying. Silent, because I had always been silent here. Tears mixed with snot and blood on my face.

Through the shared wall I heard the others—muffled grunts, wet slicing sounds, the occasional choked sob. Elara's perpetual grin must have been splitting wider as she worked. Pyra's burned skin would be cracking open again, the smell of seared flesh mingling with all the rest. Silas's frail body would be shaking so hard his bones clicked.

We were killing ourselves to stay sane.

The memory snapped like a rubber band.

I was back in the study, gasping, both hands pressed flat against my own stomach through my shirt. The letter had fallen to the desk. My gloves were clean, but I could still feel the slickness of my own guts between my fingers. The scar I had always carried just below my navel—the one I told doctors was from “a childhood accident”—throbbed as if freshly opened. I lifted my shirt with shaking hands. The old line was there, pale and thin, but for one terrifying second I saw it glistening red, edges

parted, something metallic glinting just beneath the surface.

I dropped the shirt. Swallowed bile.

The letter waited. I forced myself to read the final paragraph, though my eyes kept blurring.

We almost succeeded. For three days the radios stayed inside us, static whispering through our bodies like a shared heartbeat. Then they found us. The cleanup was... efficient. They didn't bother stitching. Just hosed the floors. But one of us survived long enough to write this. If it's you, J—run. Or finish what we started.

My pulse hammered in my ears. The friendship bracelet on the desk seemed to pulse with its own faint light. I picked it up. The stained threads were stiff, but when I squeezed, a tiny flake of something dark crumbled away—old blood, dried so long it had turned almost black. I could smell it now, faint but unmistakable.

Outside, the rain had slowed to a whisper. Inside, something else had woken up.

I reached for the phone. Naomi's number was already on the screen before I stopped myself. Not yet. Not until I understood what else this box still held.

My reflection in the dark window looked back with eyes that weren't entirely mine anymore. Behind them, just for

an instant, I saw the painted smile—stretched too wide,
black holes where eyes should be—watching from the
inside.

I closed the box lid, but I didn't lock it.

Some doors, once opened, never really close.

CHAPTER 3 – THE STATIC IN THE BONES

Washington, D.C. – Josva's Townhouse, 12:03 AM

I sat there in the study long after the letter had gone still in my hands, the house settling around me like an old coat I no longer trusted. The rain had eased into a soft, steady hiss against the windows, but inside my skull the sound of my own blood still roared—wet, rhythmic, the way it had pulsed out around my wrist in that memory. I pressed both palms flat against the desk, grounding myself in the cool mahogany, and counted my breaths the way I'd once counted the drips in the cell. One. Two. Three. The scar below my navel throbbed in time, a dull echo that felt too alive.

I told myself it was over. The letter was read. The box was closed. Tomorrow I had a 7 a.m. strategy call with the campaign manager, a noon flight to Chicago, a life that didn't include concrete rooms or radios buried in guts. But the artifacts on the desk refused to be ignored. The brooch caught the lamplight, its tiny silver strings glinting like spider silk. I picked it up before I could stop myself.

The metal was colder than it should have been. My thumb traced the puppet silhouette, and the dried blood in the crevices flaked away in tiny dark curls. That was when the second wave hit—not a memory this time, but an echo. Not sight. Sound.

I was back in the cell, but hours after the carving. The radio was inside me now, a hard, foreign weight pressing against my spine. Every shallow breath shifted it, scraping metal against raw tissue. The pain had dulled to a deep, nauseating ache that radiated through my pelvis and up into my ribs, but it was the static that kept me conscious. The little speaker had survived the intrusion. Through the thin wall of my abdomen I could hear it—faint, tinny music from some forgotten station, a children’s lullaby warped by distance and blood.

And then, from the next cell, another radio answered.

Three soft taps on the concrete. *Tap. Tap. Tap.* Elara’s code. I tapped back with a blood-crusting knuckle, the motion pulling at the fresh wound. A wet tearing sensation bloomed low in my belly, and I felt something warm trickle down my side again. Not a lot. Just enough to remind me the seal wasn’t perfect.

Silas’s wall answered next—four weak taps, then a pause as his frail lungs fought for air. I pictured him on the other side: green rags soaked through, his thin chest rising in shallow jerks while the radio he’d forced between his ribs crackled the same lullaby. Pyra’s response came last—two sharp knocks, then silence. Her burns would be weeping again where the metal touched seared skin; I could almost smell the faint char of it mixing with the copper fog of all our blood.

We lay like that for what felt like days, four radios humming inside four ruined bodies, sharing a single broken song through the walls. The static wasn't just sound anymore. It was in our bones, vibrating through intestine and muscle and nerve until the pain itself had a melody.

I blinked hard and the study snapped back into focus. The brooch was still in my hand, but now my fingers were trembling so badly the silver puppet seemed to twitch on its strings. A single drop of fresh sweat rolled down my wrist and landed on the metal, mixing with the old blood. I set it down carefully, as if it might bite.

The friendship bracelet lay beside it, threads stiff with age. I didn't want to touch it. I touched it anyway. The moment my fingertip brushed the stained strands, the echo deepened.

I heard the cleanup crew before I saw them—boots in the corridor, heavy and deliberate, the low hiss of pressurized hoses dragging across tile. They didn't speak. They never did. Just the scrape of the cell door, the sudden glare of a flashlight that made my eyes water even through closed lids. The air changed instantly: colder, sharper, laced with the sharp bite of industrial bleach that burned the back of my throat.

They found Elara first. I heard the wet slap of her body being rolled over, the unmistakable *plop* of something

heavy and slick sliding out of her opened abdomen and hitting the concrete with a soft, meaty thud. A male voice muttered low, almost bored, “Jesus, they really did it this time.” Then the hose opened—cold, high-pressure spray that hit exposed tissue with a vicious *smack*. I heard the water strike raw intestine, the sound like slapping wet leather, then the sickening gurgle as it forced blood, bile, and loose coils of gut across the floor toward the drain. The smell rolled through the vents in a thick wave: bleach mixed with the hot-copper reek of fresh blood and the faint, sour rot that had already begun at the edges of her wounds. Elara didn’t make a sound. Her perpetual grin, I realized later, had finally split all the way to the bone, the flesh parting with a quiet, wet tear as the water pressure peeled it wider.

They came for Silas next. His body was so light they lifted it like a sack of wet rags. I heard the radio clatter out of him onto the concrete—still playing, faint and tinny—until a boot came down with a wet crunch that sent fragments of plastic and circuitry skittering. The hose followed, longer this time, because Silas had bled more than the rest of us. The water ran pink for minutes, swirling with threads of tissue and the thin, dark sludge of ruptured organs that had been forced too deep. I could almost see it: his frail ribcage collapsing inward as the pressure hosed out what was left of him, the sound a rhythmic *splatter-squelch* that echoed off the walls.

Pyra fought. Even half-dead she fought. I heard the scuffle, the wet smack of a baton against burned flesh that split open like overripe fruit, her choked scream turning into a gargle as the hose hit her full force mid-struggle. The water stripped away scabs and charred skin in long, curling sheets; I heard them hit the floor with soft, heavy plops. The smell drifted through the vents—seared meat, bleach, shit, and the raw panic-sweat of a child who knew she was already gone. It coated the back of my throat, thick and oily, the way it still did sometimes in nightmares.

I was last. By then I could barely move. They cut the radio out of me with surgical shears—no anesthetic, just two men pinning my shoulders while the third sliced. The blades parted skin I'd already opened once; the sound was wetter the second time, like ripping soaked cloth soaked in warm syrup. I felt the device slide free in a sudden rush of blood and bile that splattered across the floor and up the wall in a hot arc. The relief was worse than the pain—my body collapsed inward around the new emptiness, organs shifting with a sickening internal slither, like wet ropes sliding over one another in the dark. One of the men cursed as a loop of intestine threatened to follow the radio out; he shoved it back in with a gloved hand that squelched against raw meat.

They left me alive. Barely. Stitched me with rough black thread that pulled too tight, the needle punching through

swollen flesh with audible pops. Then they dumped me in a different wing with a new name and a story about a car accident. The others... the others weren't so lucky.

I came back to myself on my knees beside the desk, one hand pressed hard against my stomach as if I could hold everything inside. The bracelet had fallen to the carpet. My breathing was ragged, but steady. The static was gone. For now.

I stood slowly, legs shaking, and crossed to the window. The city lights blurred through the rain-streaked glass. Somewhere out there, people were sleeping in warm beds, dreaming ordinary dreams. I pressed my forehead to the cool pane and whispered the only thing that still felt true.

“They didn't finish the job.”

The brooch on the desk caught the light again, its silver strings trembling as if pulled by invisible fingers.

I didn't close the box this time. I left it open like an invitation.

Because the static was still there—faint, inside my bones, waiting for the next frequency.

And for the first time since Miami, I wasn't afraid of what it might say.

CHAPTER 4 – THE FREQUENCY RETURNS

Washington, D.C. – Josva's Townhouse, 12:27 AM

I stayed at the window longer than I should have, forehead against the cool glass, watching rain trace silver paths down the pane like veins under thin skin. The whisper still lingered in my mouth—"They didn't finish the job"—tasting of copper and old bleach. My scar burned now, a steady pulse that matched the rain's rhythm, as if the thing I'd once shoved inside myself was waking up again. I told myself it was just adrenaline, just memory playing tricks. I had survived Miami. I had buried Sider. I had built a life on top of the grave. This was nothing.

But when I turned back to the desk, the Polaroid had moved.

It lay half an inch closer to the edge than I remembered. The yellow-coated figure in the background—no longer half-hidden—stared straight out of the cracked plastic, black eye-holes boring into mine. The painted smile had stretched wider, splitting at the corners where the paper had begun to tear. My stomach clenched. I hadn't touched it since the last echo. No one else was in the house.

I reached for the bourbon instead. The glass was warm, the liquid burned going down, but it did nothing to quiet the faint crackle now threading through the silence. Not in

my head. In the room. A child's lullaby, warped and distant, bleeding from the speakers of my laptop—speakers I had never turned on.

I crossed the study in three strides and slammed the lid shut. The music stopped. For two heartbeats there was only rain and my own breathing. Then it started again, softer, from inside the open box.

My hands moved before my mind caught up. I lifted the velvet square that had cradled the envelope and felt a false bottom give way with a soft click. Beneath it lay two new horrors I had somehow missed in the first rush of discovery.

The first was a jagged shard of black plastic no bigger than my palm—half of the old radio casing, edges crusted with something dark and flaked. My own blood from all those years ago, dried to the color of rust. The second was a microcassette tape, label handwritten in the same desperate loops: *For J – Play when they come back.*

The static swelled the instant my fingers brushed the plastic. Not memory this time. Real. Inside my bones and outside them at once.

I didn't want to play the tape. I carried it to the old dictaphone I kept on the shelf for campaign notes, the one that still used actual cassettes because I hated how easily digital files could be wiped. The moment I slid it in and

pressed play, the study lights dimmed as if the house itself were listening.

The voice that spilled out was mine—but younger, raw, every word forced through teeth clenched against pain.

They didn't just clean us up. They rebuilt us. After the hoses, after they cut the radios out, they strapped us to the steel tables again. Needles this time. Long, thin ones they slid between the stitches, injecting something cold that burned like acid through every vein. I felt it spread—first in my gut where the wound still wept, then up my spine, into my skull. They called it “frequency alignment.” Said it would make us better listeners.

The voice cracked, and I heard the wet sound of someone trying not to vomit.

They made us watch while they... adjusted the others. Elara's grin—they peeled it open wider with clamps so the new wires could reach the nerves. I heard the skin tear, slow and deliberate, like wet paper. Pyra's burns—they poured something viscous into the open sores, and the smell... God, the smell of melting flesh mixed with whatever chemical they used. Silas screamed when they forced the second implant between his ribs; I heard the bone give way with a soft pop, then the gurgle as fluid filled his lungs. They told us it was mercy. That the new signals would let us hear the real voices—the ones that matter. The ones who run everything.

I gripped the edge of the desk so hard the wood creaked. My own scar flared white-hot, as if invisible needles were sliding home again. I could feel the cold spread through my abdomen, the phantom pressure of something foreign settling against my spine. The voice on the tape kept going, quieter now, almost reverent.

They said we were never meant to be ordinary kids. We were prototypes. Future assets. Politicians. Advisors. People who would smile for cameras while the strings pulled from inside. And the worst part, J? I think it worked. Because I can still hear them. Even now. Whispering orders through the static.

The tape hissed, then clicked off.

Silence crashed down. The study lights steadied. But the air felt thicker, charged, like the moment before lightning strikes. I looked at the Polaroid again. The figure was closer still—almost filling the frame now, yellow paper coat creased like real fabric, black holes somehow deeper, wetter. I blinked and it snapped back to where it had been. My pulse hammered in my throat.

I crossed to the window, needing air, needing anything but the box. The reflection staring back wasn't quite me. The scar on my cheek looked fresh. Behind my own eyes, just for a heartbeat, that painted smile flickered.

Then I heard it.

Three soft taps on the wall behind the bookshelf. *Tap. Tap. Tap.* Elara's old code. The sound came from inside the house—from the shared wall with the empty guest room that had never been used.

My blood turned to ice.

The laptop speakers crackled to life on their own. A new voice, distorted, layered with static, spoke directly into the room.

“Subject T reporting. You left the door open, J.”

My phone lit up on the desk. Unknown number. The screen flashed once, twice, then the call connected without me touching it.

A child's voice—small, tired, impossibly close—whispered through the speaker.

“Are you ready to finish what we started?”

The tapping began again. Closer this time. Not on the wall.

On the study door.

CHAPTER 5 – THE DOOR THAT SHOULD NOT OPEN

Washington, D.C. – Josva’s Townhouse, 12:29 AM

The phone burned against my ear like a brand. The child’s voice lingered in the silence after its question—“Are you ready to finish what we started?”—breathing in slow, wet pulls that didn’t match any living lungs I’d ever heard.

Three more taps came from the study door, each one perfectly spaced, the sound traveling through the wood with the weight of small knuckles on concrete. Not imagined. Not in my head. Real. Ten feet away. The house was locked. The alarms were set. No one should have been able to reach that hallway without me hearing footsteps on the creaking boards.

I lowered the phone but didn’t disconnect. My own voice came out hoarse, barely above a whisper. “Who is this?”

A soft giggle answered, layered with static. “You already know, Thorne. You carved me into your bones.”

The name hit like a scalpel between the ribs. Thorne. The deaf boy who had died carving a radio into his own gut. The name I had buried with Sider in that Miami alley. My scar flared hot, a sudden lance of pain that made my knees buckle. I caught myself on the desk, breath ragged.

The tapping stopped.

Then the door handle turned—slowly, deliberately—from the outside.

I lunged forward and slammed my shoulder against the wood just as the latch clicked. The door held, but the pressure on the other side didn't relent. Something small and insistent pushed back, testing. The air in the study dropped ten degrees in a heartbeat; my breath fogged in front of my face. The Polaroid on the desk fluttered though there was no breeze, and the yellow-coated figure inside it had turned its head to watch me.

My phone crackled again. The child's voice was no longer on the line—it was in the room, right behind my left ear.

“Open it, Thorne. Or I'll open you.”

I spun, heart hammering so hard it felt like it would split my sternum. Nothing stood there. Only the open box and the artifacts glowing faintly under the lamp. But the voice stayed close, intimate, the way a memory crawls inside your skull.

And then the memory took me—harder and deeper than before.

I wasn't in the study anymore. I was strapped to the steel table in Hollowbrook's adjustment wing, wrists and ankles pinned by leather cuffs that bit into skin already raw from earlier struggles. The radios had been cut out hours ago; my abdomen was a throbbing ruin of rough

black stitches and weeping holes. The overhead lights buzzed like dying flies. Two white-coated figures moved in my peripheral vision, their faces blurred behind surgical masks.

One of them leaned over me, needle in hand—long, silver, threaded with something thin and black that glinted like wire. “Frequency alignment,” he said calmly. “This will make you listen better.”

The needle slid between two of my stitches without warning. The pain was surgical lightning. I felt the wire burrow through the inflamed tissue of my abdominal wall, scraping against exposed muscle, then deeper—pushing past the slick loops of intestine that still shifted and twitched from the earlier violation. Blood welled around the entry point, warm and steady, running down my sides in thin rivers that cooled instantly on the steel. The second needle went in lower, just above my hipbone. This one found a nerve. My entire left leg jerked violently, foot slamming against the restraint as white-hot fire raced up my spine and exploded behind my eyes.

They didn’t stop. Wire after wire threaded through living meat, weaving a new web inside me. I felt one coil around the base of my stomach, tightening like a noose every time I breathed. Another slipped between two ribs with a soft, wet *pop* of cartilage giving way. The smell hit me then—my own blood mixed with the antiseptic tang and

the faint char of cauterized tissue where they sealed the entry points with a small electric pen. Each sizzle sent fresh smoke curling up, the odor of cooking flesh so thick I gagged on it.

Through the pain I heard the others on adjacent tables. Elara's perpetual grin stretched wider as they worked on her face, the wet rip of skin parting under clamps. Pyra's burned flesh crackled when they poured the conductive gel into her open sores. Silas's frail body convulsed so hard I heard a rib snap like green wood.

The voice on the phone whispered in my ear, pulling me back to the present. "We're still connected, Thorne. Feel it?"

The study door handle rattled violently. The temperature plunged again; frost formed on the windowpane in delicate spider-web patterns. My scar burned as if the wires were still there, alive, pulling.

I staggered to the desk, hands shaking so badly I almost dropped the envelope I'd sealed away earlier. The one with the desperate handwriting. The full letter. I tore it open because I had no choice anymore—the tapping had become a steady rhythm against the wood, and the voice was counting down in my head.

The parchment unfolded with a dry crackle.

If you're reading this, J, then the strings are already pulling again. They never cut us loose. They only lengthened the cord.

I kept reading, the words blurring through sweat and tears
I refused to acknowledge.

We didn't just die that night. They brought us back. Piece by piece. The wires are still inside. Every time you smile for a camera, every time you shake a donor's hand, every time you lie to the country about who you really are—they tighten. We are the Shadow Puppets, and the show never ended. The finale is coming. Finish it, Thorne. Cut the wires. Or we will cut them for you—from the inside.

My knees hit the carpet. The letter slipped from my fingers.

The study door burst inward with a crack of splintering wood.

But the hallway beyond was empty.

The tapping now came from inside the room—right behind me.

And my phone, still clutched in my white-knuckled grip, lit up with a new message from the unknown number:

We're home.

CHAPTER 6 – THE CONDUCTOR ARRIVES

Washington, D.C. – Josva’s Townhouse, 12:31 AM

The word on my phone screen pulsed like a fresh wound: *We’re home*. I stared at it until the letters blurred, my thumb hovering useless over the power button. Behind me the tapping had stopped, but the silence was worse—thicker, expectant, the kind that presses against your eardrums right before something breaks. The study door hung crooked on its hinges, wood splintered where the latch had torn free, yet the hallway beyond remained empty. No footsteps. No shadow. Just the faint, metallic smell of old blood drifting in like an uninvited guest.

I turned slowly, every nerve screaming at me to run, but my legs refused. The air in the room had gone dead still, frost now crawling across the window in jagged veins. My breath fogged in short, sharp bursts. And then the static returned—not from the laptop, not from the tape, but from inside my own chest, vibrating through the old scar as if something buried there had just been switched on.

A new voice slid into the silence. Soft. Female. Calm in the way a scalpel is calm.

“Hello, Thorne. It’s been a long time.”

I whipped around. The desk was empty except for the open box. But the voice was inches from my face, warm

breath ghosting across my cheek even though nothing stood there. My scar ignited—white-hot, as if the wires were tightening again. I pressed both hands over it, feeling the raised line through my shirt, half expecting blood to well between my fingers.

“Who—” My voice cracked. “Who the hell are you?”

A low laugh answered, musical and ancient at once. “You carved me a name once. Vesper. The Fifth. The one who taught the four of you how to hide the radios. The Conductor.”

Vesper. The name landed like a stone in deep water, sending ripples through memories I hadn’t known I owned. Not one of the four I remembered—Elara, Pyra, Silas, me. A fifth. Older. The first success. The prototype they had perfected before they broke the rest of us.

The static swelled. My knees buckled and I caught the edge of the desk, but the room was already dissolving around me.

I was back in Hollowbrook, but not in my cell. A larger chamber—observation room—with one-way glass and monitors. I was strapped to a table again, but this time I wasn’t alone. A girl—maybe fourteen, maybe twenty, it was impossible to tell—stood at the foot of the table. Pale skin, dark hair cropped short, eyes the color of wet concrete. She wore the same tattered yellow coat the

figure in the Polaroid had worn, but on her it looked almost regal, the paper folds crisp, the painted smile on the collar faint and knowing.

She leaned down. Her voice was the same one now whispering in my study.

“They started with me, Thorne. Before the cells. Before the isolation. I was the first string they pulled. Subject Zero. They told my parents I had ‘exceptional neural plasticity.’ What they really meant was I could hear frequencies no child should. The voices in the walls. The ones that run everything.”

Her fingers—small, cold—traced the fresh stitches across my abdomen. Where she touched, the pain sharpened into something almost pleasurable, like the first note of a song you’ve waited your whole life to hear. I felt the wires inside me respond, humming in harmony with something inside her.

“They opened me first,” she continued, voice gentle, almost loving. “Not with glass or nails. With precision. A single incision right here—” she pressed two fingers just below my sternum “—and they threaded the original conductor wire straight to the vagus nerve. No radio. Something older. Something that let me feel the entire building breathing. Every heartbeat in every cell. Every scream before it left the throat.”

I watched—helpless—as she lifted her own shirt. A thin silver scar ran the length of her torso, perfectly healed, almost beautiful. But when she turned slightly, I saw the truth: the scar wasn't a line. It was a seam. Tiny metallic points glinted beneath the skin like the teeth of a zipper, waiting.

“They called me the Conductor because I could make the rest of you sing on cue,” she whispered. “I taught you the tapping codes. I told you where to cut so the radios would stay hidden longest. I wanted you to feel what I felt. Connected. Necessary.”

The memory shifted. I saw the others through her eyes—four small shapes on adjacent tables, screaming while white coats worked. But Vesper stood between us like a conductor at the podium, humming a single note that made our pain sync into rhythm. When Elara's grin was stretched, Vesper nodded approval. When Pyra's burns were reopened and packed with conductive gel, Vesper's eyes shone with pride. When Silas's rib cracked, she caught the note and held it until his scream became part of the music.

And when they came for me—the last one—she had leaned close and pressed her forehead to mine.

“Survive,” she'd whispered. “The strings will call us home one day.”

The study snapped back into focus with a jolt that left me gasping. I was on the floor now, back against the desk, sweat soaking through my shirt. The voice—Vesper’s voice—was no longer behind me. It came from the open box.

From the Polaroid.

The yellow-coated figure had stepped out of the frame somehow—still two-dimensional, still paper and ink, but moving. It stood on the desk like a living cut-out, head tilted, painted smile stretched wide enough to split the photo paper. Black eye-holes glistened as if wet.

“I never left, Thorne,” Vesper said through the image. “I’ve been riding the frequency inside you since they stitched us back together. Every speech you gave. Every vote you cast. Every time you looked in the mirror and told yourself you were free—I was listening. Conducting.”

My phone vibrated in my hand. The screen showed a live feed now—my own study, from an angle that didn’t exist. I was on the floor. And behind me, faint but unmistakable, stood the outline of a girl in a yellow paper coat, one hand resting lightly on my shoulder. Her fingers were pressed exactly over the scar.

The image on the desk smiled wider.

“I’m home now,” she said. “And the others are waking up. Elara wants to grin again. Pyra wants to burn. Silas wants to breathe without rattling. But first... we need you to finish what we started. Cut the final string. Or we’ll cut it from inside all of you.”

The Polaroid fluttered. The cut-out figure took one paper step closer to the edge of the desk.

My scar throbbed in perfect time with the static.

And somewhere deeper—beneath the fear, beneath the horror—a single, terrible question rose like the first note of a new song:

What if I didn’t want to cut it?

CHAPTER 7 – THE FIRST STRING TIGHTENS

Washington, D.C. – Josva’s Townhouse, 12:35 AM

I stayed on the floor because standing felt like surrender. The Polaroid cut-out of Vesper had stepped fully onto the desk now, two-dimensional paper legs bending with impossible grace, the painted smile curving wider until the edges of the photo paper began to fray and curl like burning film. Her black eye-holes weren’t empty anymore. Something glistened inside them—tiny metallic threads, twitching like living antennae. My scar throbbed in perfect sync with those threads, a low, rhythmic pull that made my stomach muscles clench as if invisible fingers were tugging from within.

“You’re wondering how it all began,” she said, voice soft as a lullaby hummed through bone. “Not the radios. Not the four of you. Me. Subject Zero. The first string.”

I wanted to look away. I couldn’t. The paper figure tilted her head, and I felt the motion inside my own neck—a gentle, coaxing twist that made my jaw slacken. My phone lay forgotten beside me, screen still glowing with that impossible live feed. In it I watched myself on the carpet, and behind my shoulder the outline of Vesper grew sharper, her paper hand now resting fully on my image, fingers pressing exactly where the wires slept.

“It started in 1998,” she continued, stepping closer to the desk’s edge. Each paper footfall left faint ink smudges on the mahogany. “Hollowbrook wasn’t a psychiatric institute then. It was a listening post. The government wanted ears inside children’s minds—kids no one would miss. Orphans with ‘anomalous neural patterns.’ I was the first they found. A six-year-old girl who could hear radio static in her teeth when thunderstorms rolled through upstate New York. They told my foster parents I was going to a special school for gifted children. They never saw me again.”

The memory didn’t slam into me this time. It unfolded gently, like a thread being drawn through a needle. I was still on the study floor, but I felt her past as if it were happening behind my own eyes.

A sterile white room. Vesper—smaller, real flesh and blood—strapped to a smaller table. No glass shard. No desperation. Just two men in lab coats and a woman with kind eyes who lied through her teeth. They placed a simple radio headset on her shaved head. Nothing invasive. Not yet. Just low-frequency waves pulsing through her skull. She remembered giggling at first. Then the giggles turned to screams when the waves found something that shouldn’t have been there—a natural resonance in her vagus nerve that turned her body into an antenna.

“They opened me that same night,” Vesper whispered from the desk. “Not to hurt. To tune. One careful incision right here—” her paper finger traced a line down her own torso on the Polaroid “—and they slid the first conductor wire straight to the nerve cluster. No anesthetic for the final test. They needed me conscious to confirm the signal.”

I felt it with her. The cold steel parting skin just below the sternum. The wet, precise parting of tissue layers—fat, fascia, then the slick, pulsing surface of the nerve itself. No blood at first; they cauterized as they went. The smell of seared meat filled the memory, faint but unmistakable, and my own mouth filled with saliva like I might be sick. The wire was thin, almost beautiful, silver threaded with microscopic filaments that drank in every signal. When they activated it, Vesper’s entire body lit up from the inside. She heard the heartbeat of every person in the building. She heard the lies the doctors told each other. She heard the future.

“That’s when they decided on the puppets,” she said. “If one child could conduct, four more could perform. They designed the Shadow Puppets program around me. I became the template. The prototype who never broke because I chose not to. I taught them how to smile while the wires sang.”

The paper figure crouched now, eye-holes level with mine. Her painted smile split further, a fresh tear opening at the corner like a fresh wound. I felt the same tear inside my own cheek—my old Miami scar pulling tight, as if something beneath it wanted to grin too.

“You were always my favorite, Thorne,” she murmured. “The deaf one who learned to listen through pain. When I showed you how to carve the radios, I wasn’t saving you. I was completing the set. Five strings. One orchestra.”

My hand moved without permission. It rose, fingers trembling, and touched the scar through my shirt. The moment skin met fabric, the pull intensified. I felt the wires—not memory, not echo—real and alive, shifting inside my abdomen like restless snakes waking from hibernation. A warm trickle slid down my side beneath the cloth. Not sweat. Thicker. I didn’t dare look.

Vesper’s paper hand mirrored mine, reaching out. When her inked fingertips brushed the air above my real hand, electricity arced between us. My scar split open—not visibly, but I felt the stitches of memory tear. Fresh heat bloomed. The taste of blood touched my tongue though my mouth was empty.

“The others are stirring,” she said. “Elara’s grin is cracking wider in the dark. Pyra’s burns are itching for new flame. Silas’s lungs are filling again. But the finale needs all five. You have to bring the box to the place

where it began. Hollowbrook is gone, but the basement is still there—waiting under a parking garage in upstate New York. Cut the final string there... or let us pull it from inside you. From inside everyone you love.”

My phone screen flickered. The live feed now showed Naomi’s apartment across town—her sleeping form, unaware. Behind her bed, faint paper outlines were forming on the wall. Yellow. Smiling.

Vesper stood to her full paper height. “Your campaign speech tomorrow. The one about ‘healing a divided nation.’ Smile wide, Thorne. Let them see the strings. Or I’ll make you.”

The Polaroid figure took one step backward and folded itself neatly back into the photograph. The black eye-holes remained fixed on me.

The study lights steadied. The frost on the window melted in sudden rivulets like tears. But the warm trickle beneath my shirt continued. When I finally lifted my hand, my fingertips came away red.

Real blood.

My scar had opened—just a hairline fissure—but enough.

And from deep inside the wound, faint as a child’s lullaby, the static began to play again.

(Word count: 1,006)

TO BE CONTINUED...

CHAPTER 8 – THE BLEEDING SYMPHONY

Washington, D.C. – Josva’s Townhouse, 12:39 AM

Blood dripped steadily from the reopened scar, soaking through my shirt in a warm, widening stain that clung to my skin like a lover’s embrace gone wrong. I stared at my red-smeared fingertips, the color vivid under the lamplight, and felt no panic. No urge to call for help. Instead, a strange calm settled over me, the static from inside the wound humming a melody that drowned out the rain now pounding harder against the windows. The Polaroid lay flat again, Vesper’s figure frozen in the background once more—but her eye-holes still gleamed with that wet, knowing glint.

I pressed my palm over the fissure, feeling the slow ooze pulse between my fingers. It wasn’t deep enough to kill me. Not yet. But every throb sent fresh waves of that old frequency through my veins, whispering promises I hadn’t asked for. Power. Control. The kind of strings that let you pull others without them noticing.

Vesper’s voice echoed faintly from the photo, softer now, almost affectionate. “The origin didn’t start with me in that white room, Thorne. It went back further. To the voices we all heard before the wires. The ones that chose us.”

I wanted to ignore her. To stand and stumble to the bathroom, stitch myself shut with dental floss if I had to. But my body betrayed me. My free hand reached for the box instead, fingers dipping into the velvet lining where the false bottom had hidden the tape. Beneath it now—impossibly, as if it had always been there—lay a new artifact: a small, rusted keychain with a miniature puppet dangling from it. The puppet was carved from what looked like bone, yellowed with age, its strings tiny silver wires that looped around fragile limbs. The head was a crude skull, mouth etched in a perpetual scream.

The moment I touched it, the static surged. My scar split wider—not much, just a fraction of an inch—but enough to send a fresh trickle down my abdomen, mixing with sweat and pooling in the waistband of my pants. The pain was exquisite, a sharp note that harmonized with the hum inside me. And with it came another thread of the origin, unraveling slow and deliberate.

I saw Vesper again, but younger still—four years old, maybe—in a different place. Not Hollowbrook. A crumbling orphanage in the shadow of a Cold War-era radio tower, the kind the government denied ever existed. The tower loomed outside her window, humming day and night with low-frequency signals meant for submarines or spies or God knows what. But Vesper heard them differently. They weren't codes. They were songs. Lullabies that told her to do things.

One night, the voices told her to open the caretaker. She did. With a kitchen knife from the drawer she wasn't tall enough to reach without a chair. The memory played out behind my eyes: the blade parting the woman's throat in a single, curious swipe. The wet gargle as blood sprayed in an arc, painting the orphanage wall in red ribbons. Vesper watched, humming along to the tower's frequency, as the caretaker clutched at the gash, fingers slipping in the slick warmth, her eyes wide with the kind of surprise that turns to blank nothing. The blood pooled on the linoleum, thick and dark, reflecting the tower's red warning light like a mirror.

"That was the first string," Vesper whispered from the Polaroid. "Not pulled by them. Pulled by me. The government found me after that. Saw the potential. Hollowbrook was built around what I could already do. Amplify. Conduct. Make the music play through others."

The bone puppet in my hand twitched. Its tiny skull head lolled, the etched scream seeming to widen. My own mouth pulled at the corners, mirroring it against my will. The blood from my scar had reached my thigh now, warm and insistent, but I didn't move to stop it. Part of me—the part that had always listened to the static—wondered what it would feel like to let it keep flowing. To open wider. To conduct.

My phone buzzed again. The screen lit with Naomi's name this time. Not a call. A text: *Can't sleep. Coming over. Need to talk about tomorrow's speech.*

I stared at the words. The campaign. The spotlight. Healing a divided nation. Lies I had scripted myself, but now they felt like notes in Vesper's symphony. My thumb hovered over the reply button. *Don't come. It's not safe.* But my fingers typed something else: *Door's open. Hurry.*

The message sent before I could delete it. A soft laugh bubbled up from my throat—not mine. Vesper's. The Polaroid figure nodded approvingly.

“See?” she said. “You’re learning to pull. Naomi will be the first audience. Elara’s grin will suit her.”

Horror should have flooded me. Instead, a thrill chased the pain—a dark, electric rush that made my scar throb with pleasure. I pictured Naomi walking through the splintered study door, her eyes widening at the blood, at me. I pictured her face stretching into that perpetual rictus, the skin splitting slow and wet at the corners as the wires found their way in. The sound it would make. The way her blood would mix with mine on the carpet.

No. I shoved the thought down, but it clung like the stain on my shirt. My hand pressed harder against the scar, trying to stem the flow, but the pressure only made it worse. A fresh gush welled up, hot and thick, spilling over

my knuckles. The room spun for a second, the edges blurring as blood loss tugged at my vision.

Outside, headlights swept the driveway. Naomi's car. The engine cut off. Footsteps on the wet pavement, hurried.

The bone puppet in my other hand warmed, as if alive. Its silver wires glinted, reflecting the lamplight like tiny scalpels.

Vesper's voice hummed from inside the wound. "Let her in, Thorne. The orchestra needs more players. And you... you'll lead us all soon enough."

The front door creaked open downstairs—no alarm, though I had set it hours ago. Naomi called my name, her voice echoing up the stairs, laced with worry.

I stood slowly, legs unsteady, blood dripping steadily onto the carpet with soft, rhythmic plops. The static swelled into a full melody now, pulling me toward the study door like a marionette on strings.

And for the first time, I didn't fight it.

I welcomed it.

To Be Continued...

CHAPTER 9 – THE PULL OF THE STRINGS

Washington, D.C. – Josva’s Townhouse, 12:41 AM

Naomi’s footsteps echoed up the stairs like the steady drip of blood from my scar—slow, inevitable, each one pulling me tighter into the melody humming through my veins. I stood in the study doorway, one hand still pressed against the wound, feeling the warm slickness seep between my fingers and drip onto the hardwood with soft, accusing plops. The blood had soaked my shirt completely now, turning the fabric into a clinging second skin that reeked of copper and something sweeter, like the powdered decay from the box. My other hand clutched the bone puppet keychain, its tiny silver wires digging into my palm like eager hooks.

I should have locked the front door. Shouted a warning. Told her to run. But the static inside me—the frequency Vesper had tuned all those years ago—whispered otherwise. *Let her see. Let her feel. The orchestra grows with every new voice.*

“Josva?” Naomi’s call was closer now, laced with that familiar edge of concern she reserved for my late-night binges or the scars I never explained. The front door clicked shut behind her. No alarm blared. The system I had armed hours ago stayed silent, as if complicit.

I stepped into the hallway, leaving a trail of crimson footprints. The lights flickered once, casting long shadows that twisted like marionette limbs on the walls. Vesper's voice hummed from the Polaroid in the study behind me, faint but insistent: "Pull the string, Thorne. Make her dance."

Naomi appeared at the top of the stairs, coat dripping rain, her dark hair plastered to her forehead. Her eyes—sharp, always so sharp—widened at the sight of me. "Jesus, Josva, what happened? You're bleeding—"

She rushed forward, hands outstretched, but I raised mine first—the one holding the bone puppet. The motion was mine, but not mine. The silver wires glinted under the hall light, and for a split second, I saw them extend like living threads, reaching toward her.

She froze mid-step, her face paling. "What is that? And why are you smiling like that?"

I hadn't realized I was. My mouth had pulled wide, the old Miami scar splitting at the edge with a faint, wet tear. A thin line of blood trickled down my cheek, mirroring the one on my abdomen. The pain was distant now, muffled by the static's song—a symphony building to crescendo.

“It’s nothing,” I heard myself say, voice smooth as campaign rhetoric. “Just an old wound reopening. Come in. We need to talk about the speech.”

She hesitated, glancing at the splintered study door. “You look like hell. Let me call an ambulance—”

“No.” The word came out sharper than I intended, laced with Vesper’s timbre. I stepped closer, the bone puppet dangling between us like a talisman. Naomi’s gaze locked on it, and I saw the moment recognition flickered—not of the object, but of something in my eyes. Fear bloomed in hers, raw and beautiful.

The static surged. Another thread of Vesper’s origin unraveled in my mind, pulling me under just enough to taste it.

I saw her at eight, after the orphanage “incident.” Hollowbrook’s early days—a makeshift lab in a converted bunker, wires snaking across concrete floors like veins. The voices from the radio tower had grown louder in her head, demanding more than blood. They wanted echoes. So Vesper conducted her first real test: a boy from the next room over, frail and forgotten. She didn’t use a knife this time. Just her hands and the new conductor wire in her torso.

She pressed her palm to his chest, humming the frequency. His ribs caved inward with a soft, wet crunch,

as if an invisible force had squeezed. Blood bubbled from his mouth in frothy red foam, his lungs collapsing under the pull. Vesper watched, eyes alight, as his body jerked like a puppet on taut strings—arms flailing, legs kicking in rhythmic spasms. The smell of burst organs filled the air, sharp and fecal, mixing with the ozone tang of the lab’s generators. When it was over, she smiled. “The strings don’t always cut,” she’d whispered to the corpse. “Sometimes they play.”

Back in the hallway, Naomi backed up a step. “Josva, you’re scaring me. What’s going on?”

I advanced, the bone puppet swinging gently. “The origin goes deeper, Naomi. Vesper wasn’t born a monster. She was tuned. Like a radio picking up signals from the dark. And now... she’s tuning me.”

Naomi’s back hit the wall. She fumbled for her phone, but I was faster—my free hand shot out, grabbing her wrist with a strength that surprised even me. Her skin was warm, alive, her pulse racing under my thumb like a trapped bird. I squeezed, feeling the delicate bones grind together with a faint, satisfying pop. She gasped, the sound high and sharp, her phone clattering to the floor.

“Josva—stop!”

But I didn’t. The static roared approval. I pulled her into the study, her arm twisting in my grip. She stumbled,

nearly falling into the pool of my blood on the carpet. The Polaroid on the desk fluttered as if in greeting, Vesper's paper figure stepping forward again, watching.

"See?" I said, voice dropping to a whisper. "The wires are waking. In me. In you soon."

Naomi wrenched free, cradling her wrist, eyes wild.

"What the hell is wrong with you? This isn't you!"

I laughed then—a low, resonant sound that echoed Vesper's. The bone puppet warmed in my palm, its silver wires uncoiling slightly, as if alive. I held it out to her. "It is now. The campaign? The Senate? Lies. All strings leading back to Hollowbrook. Vesper showed me. The voices chose us because we could hear them. And now... I choose you."

She lunged for the door, but I blocked her, shoving her back with one hand. She hit the desk hard, the impact rattling the artifacts. The brooch skittered across the surface, its blood-crusted edges leaving faint red streaks. Naomi's head snapped back, and a thin cut opened on her forehead—shallow, but bleeding freely. Crimson trickled down her temple, mirroring my own.

The sight ignited something primal. I stepped closer, the static guiding my hand. My fingers—still slick with my blood—brushed her cheek, smearing red across her skin. She flinched, but I held her jaw, forcing her to meet my

eyes. “Feel it,” I murmured. “The frequency. It’s beautiful.”

Her breath came in ragged bursts. “Please... Josva...”

I pressed the bone puppet to her chest, right over her heart. The silver wires twitched, piercing her shirt with tiny pricks. She screamed—a raw, tearing sound that sent a shiver of delight through me. Blood welled in small beads where the wires bit, soaking the fabric. The static in my scar harmonized with her cry, turning pain into music.

Vesper’s voice joined from the Polaroid: “Yes, Thorne. Pull her string. Make her sing.”

Naomi thrashed, but I held firm, watching as the wires burrowed deeper—not far, just enough to taste. Her skin parted with wet pops, the smell of fresh blood mingling with mine. Her eyes rolled back, body convulsing in rhythmic jerks that matched the puppet’s etched scream.

I released her then, stepping back as she slumped to the floor, gasping, blood pooling beneath her. The wires retracted into the bone, leaving tiny puncture wounds that wept red. She wasn’t dead. Not yet. Just tuned. Listening.

I knelt beside her, stroking her hair with bloody fingers. “Welcome to the orchestra, Naomi. Tomorrow’s speech will be our debut.”

She whimpered, eyes glazing with the first hints of that perpetual grin pulling at her lips.

And inside me, the static swelled to applause.

I was no longer Josva Alden, the senator chasing ghosts.

I was Thorne. The villain Vesper had always known I could be.

And the symphony had only just begun.

To Be Continued...

CHAPTER 10 – THE ULTIMATUM ECHOES

Washington, D.C. – Josva’s Townhouse, 12:43 AM

Naomi lay curled on the study carpet, her breaths shallow and ragged, blood from the puncture wounds on her chest seeping into the fibers like ink on parchment. Her eyes fluttered half-open, glazed with pain and something new — a distant, humming obedience that mirrored the static in my own veins. I knelt beside her, my scar still weeping steadily, the warmth of my blood mixing with hers where our hands touched. The bone puppet dangled from my fingers, its silver wires retracted but glistening with fresh crimson, as if sated for now.

Vesper’s voice purred from the Polaroid on the desk, her paper figure watching with tilted head. “Beautiful, Thorne. She’ll make a fine second violin. Now tune her deeper. Let the wires find her heart.”

I traced a bloody finger along Naomi’s jaw, feeling her pulse jump under my touch. She whimpered, but didn’t pull away. Part of her was already listening to the frequency—the same one that had turned Vesper from a scared child into the Conductor. The origin thread pulled again in my mind, another dark strand unraveling.

I saw Vesper at ten, in Hollowbrook’s core chamber—a room lined with humming generators and cages for the “failures.” She had graduated from simple tuning by then.

The voices from the tower demanded expansion. So she conducted her second symphony: three orphans, bound and blindfolded, their small bodies prepped with shallow incisions along their spines. Vesper stood at the center, her own scar glowing faintly under the lights as she hummed the signal.

The wires in her torso activated first, sending pulses through the air like invisible threads. The children jerked in unison, their incisions parting wider with wet, tearing sounds as phantom forces pulled at the wounds. One boy's spine arched backward until vertebrae popped like bursting bubbles, blood spraying in fine mists from the stretched skin. A girl's arms twisted inward, bones grinding with audible snaps, her screams harmonizing with Vesper's hum until her vocal cords shredded from the strain. The third— a silent one like me— simply bled out from the inside, organs rupturing in rhythmic bursts that painted the cage floor in dark, pooling slicks.

Vesper laughed through it all, her eyes alight with control. "The strings choose the players," she'd said to the dying. "And I choose the song."

Back in the study, the memory fueled me. But not in the way Vesper intended. The static in my scar hummed louder, pulling at me to finish Naomi— to press the bone puppet deeper, let the wires burrow until her heart beat in

time with mine. My hand hovered over her chest, fingers trembling with the urge.

But I hesitated.

The calm from before cracked, a sliver of the old Josva peeking through—the senator, the survivor, the one who had buried Sider and clawed his way to power on his own terms. Vesper’s frequency was strong, but so was I. Stronger, maybe. The blood loss made my vision swim, but it sharpened something else: resolve. I wasn’t her puppet. Not anymore.

“Thorne,” Vesper coaxed from the Polaroid, her paper form stepping closer to the edge. “Pull the string. Make her yours—ours.”

Naomi’s eyes met mine, pleading through the haze. “Josva... please...”

I gripped the bone puppet tighter, the silver wires biting into my palm until fresh blood welled. Then, with deliberate slowness, I stood. The room tilted, but I steadied myself against the desk. The Polaroid figure froze, as if sensing the shift.

“No,” I said, voice low and steady, laced with the static but no longer enslaved to it. “Not ours. Mine.”

Vesper's laugh echoed, tinny and distorted. "You forget, Thorne. I tuned you. The wires are mine. The symphony is mine."

I turned to face the photo, my blood dripping onto the desk in heavy drops that splattered across her paper form. The ink began to run, her painted smile smearing like melting wax. "You tuned me to listen," I growled. "But I've been listening longer than you think. To the voices beyond the tower. The ones that whisper about control—real control. Not your little orchestra games."

The static flared in protest, my scar splitting wider with a sharp, wet rip that sent pain lancing through my gut. Blood poured faster now, soaking my pants, but I ignored it. I slammed my fist down on the desk, the bone puppet clattering beside the Polaroid. "You were the prototype, Vesper. The first string. But prototypes get replaced. Upgraded."

Her paper eyes narrowed, the black holes deepening. "You can't cut me out. I'm inside you. In all of you."

I laughed then—a dark, resonant sound that started in my chest and built like thunder. Naomi stirred on the floor, her wounds clotting under the frequency's influence, her lips pulling into the beginnings of that rictus grin. But I knelt again, pressing my bloody hand over her puncture marks. The static jumped between us, but this time I

directed it— pulling the wires back, sealing her skin with a faint sizzle that smelled of cauterized flesh.

Naomi gasped, clarity returning to her eyes. “Josva... what—”

“Quiet,” I snapped, the command carrying Vesper’s timbre but twisted into my own. She obeyed, fear and awe mixing in her gaze.

I rose, turning back to the Polaroid. Vesper’s figure trembled now, the paper curling at the edges as my blood soaked in deeper. “Here’s your ultimatum, Conductor,” I said, voice cold as the steel tables we’d bled on. “Stop pulling my strings. Join me— as my second. Help me build the real symphony. The one that plays for the world, not some forgotten bunker. Or I’ll cut you out myself. Burn every thread. End you like the failures you caged.”

The static screamed in my scar, a high-pitched wail that made my ears ring. The room shook— books tumbling from shelves, the window cracking with a sharp snap. Vesper’s voice cracked through the air, no longer affectionate. “You dare? After everything I gave you?”

I leaned close to the Polaroid, my breath fogging the glass frame. “Either you stop and join me, or you die. Either way... you’re under my command now.”

The paper figure froze mid-step, then crumpled inward, folding like a discarded marionette. The static dulled to a murmur— still there, but subdued. Mine to control.

Naomi pushed herself up, wincing, her voice trembling. “Josva... what have you done?”

I helped her stand, my bloody hand leaving prints on her arm. “What I should have done years ago. Taken the stage.”

Outside, the rain hammered harder, thunder rolling like distant applause. The box on the desk hummed faintly, new artifacts shifting inside as if awakening to a new master.

And inside me, the wires sang a different tune. My tune.

The villain had arrived. And the misfortune? It was just the overture.

CHAPTER 11 – THE STRINGS SNAP BACK

Washington, D.C. – Josva's Townhouse, 12:45 AM

The Polaroid lay crumpled on the desk, Vesper's paper form twisted into a grotesque origami knot, ink bleeding from the edges where my blood had soaked through. The static in my scar had dulled to a resentful buzz—still there, coiling like a serpent ready to strike, but no longer dictating the rhythm. Naomi huddled against the wall, her puncture wounds scabbed over in unnatural haste, her eyes darting between me and the photo like a cornered animal. She clutched her chest, breaths coming in shallow gasps, but she didn't speak. Good. She was learning her place in the new order.

I paced the study, blood still trickling from my scar in lazy rivulets that stained the carpet in abstract patterns. The pain grounded me, a sharp reminder that I was alive, in control. The box hummed faintly from the desk, its contents shifting as if alive—new artifacts awakening to my command. But Vesper wasn't done. Not yet.

The crumpled photo twitched. Unfolded itself with a dry rustle, like bones cracking back into place. Vesper's figure reformed, edges frayed and smeared, but her painted smile sharper than before. Her voice crackled through the air, laced with fury and static that made the lights flicker wildly.

“You think you can command me, Thorne? You, a broken prototype? A deaf puppet who begged for my codes in the dark? I *made* you. I tuned your worthless body into something that could hear the real music. And now you spit ultimatums like you’re the maestro?”

I stopped pacing, turning to face her with a calm that masked the storm inside. My scar throbbed in defiance, but I crushed the impulse down. Blood dripped from my chin where the Miami scar had reopened further, tasting salty on my lips. I leaned over the desk, fists planted on either side of the Polaroid, my shadow engulfing her tiny form.

“Listen closely, Vesper,” I snarled, voice dropping to a venomous growl that echoed off the walls. “You were the first string, yeah—the little girl who slit throats to pretty lullabies from a tower. But that makes you obsolete. A relic. I’ve outgrown your games. Your ‘orchestra’? Pathetic. Kids bleeding out in cages while you hummed? That’s not power. That’s a child playing god with broken toys.”

The paper figure trembled, her black eye-holes flaring with phantom light. The room grew colder, frost creeping across the desk in jagged spikes. Naomi whimpered, pressing herself flatter against the wall.

Vesper’s response hissed like feedback through a blown speaker. “You dare lecture me? I felt their hearts stop

under my hands—the wet crunch of bones, the hot spray of blood painting the walls red. I conducted symphonies of agony while you cowered in silence. Join you? I’d rather rip those wires from your gut myself, loop by loop, until your intestines spill out like the worthless meat they are!”

I slammed my palm down on the photo, crumpling her again—but she unfolded faster this time, the paper slicing a shallow cut across my skin. Fresh blood welled, mixing with the ink. The static surged in my scar, trying to pull me under, but I roared back, grabbing the Polaroid and holding it inches from my face.

“Enough of your bullshit echoes!” I bellowed, spittle flecking the paper. “You think you’re the Conductor? You’re a glitch in the system—a fucked-up frequency from a dead tower! I’m giving you one chance, you spectral bitch: Stop fighting. Stop the pulling. Join me as my enforcer, my shadow blade. Help me tune the world—the senators, the presidents, the masses—into my symphony. Or I swear on the blood we both spilled in Hollowbrook, I’ll burn you out. I’ll hunt every thread of you, every hidden wire, and sever them with my bare hands. I’ll make you watch as I twist your precious origin into ash, your screams the final note in a dirge I compose. Either you bow to me now, or you die screaming in the void you crawled from. Either way, you’re mine—my tool, my weapon, my fucking echo. Choose!”

The room erupted. Books flew from shelves in a whirlwind, the window shattering in a cascade of glass that rained like brittle knives. Naomi screamed, covering her head as shards nicked her arms, drawing fresh beads of blood. The static in my scar exploded into white-hot agony, wires shifting under my skin like burrowing parasites, trying to tear me apart from the inside. I felt them coil around my organs, squeezing—my stomach contracting with a wet gurgle, bile rising in my throat.

Vesper's voice warped into a shriek that rattled my teeth. "You insolent fragment! I'll flay you alive—peel your skin in strips, expose the wires, and yank them until your spine snaps! You'll beg for the cells again, for the hoses washing away your filth!"

But I held firm, crushing the Polaroid in my fist until the paper tore. The static peaked—then stuttered. Faltered. The whirlwind died, debris clattering to the floor. The frost melted in sudden puddles.

Vesper's figure reformed one last time, smaller, edges blurred. Her voice came weak, defeated, but seething. "Fine... Maestro. I join. But remember—this symphony ends in blood. Yours or the world's."

I released the photo, letting it flutter to the desk. The static settled into a low, obedient hum. My scar sealed itself with a faint sizzle, the pain receding to a dull ache. Naomi

stared at me, terror etched in her features, but a flicker of that rictus grin still pulling at her lips.

I straightened, wiping blood from my mouth with the back of my hand. “Good choice, Vesper. Now... let’s tune the campaign speech. The nation needs to hear our music.”

Outside, thunder cracked like a whip, but inside, the strings were mine. And the misfortune? It was spreading, note by bloody note.

CHAPTER 12 – THE INVINCIBLE MAESTRO

Washington, D.C. – Josva’s Townhouse, 12:47 AM

The study reeked of blood and shattered glass, the air thick with the metallic tang that clung to my tongue like victory. Vesper’s crumpled Polaroid lay silent on the desk, her submission a fragile truce humming through the subdued static in my scar. Naomi stood shakily beside me now, her wounds sealed under my command, her eyes a mix of terror and reluctant devotion. She touched her chest gingerly, where the wires had tasted her, and whispered, “What... what do we do now?”

I wiped the blood from my hands on my ruined shirt, feeling the power coil inside me like a loaded spring. “We expand the orchestra,” I said, voice steady, commanding. “The speech tomorrow isn’t just words. It’s the overture. But first... we need allies. Or instruments.”

My phone buzzed on the floor amid the debris—a text from Eva, my chief of staff, the stoic one who had always smelled my lies but never called them out. *Heard from Naomi you’re up late prepping. Need me there? Campaign’s heating up.*

Perfect. Deception had always been my forte, even before the wires. I typed back: *Yes. Urgent. Come now. Door’s open.*

Naomi's eyes widened. "Eva? Josva, she's not part of this —"

I silenced her with a look, the static flaring just enough to make her flinch. "She will be. Or she won't be anything."

The front door creaked open minutes later—no knock, just Eva's efficient heels clicking on the foyer tiles. She called up the stairs, voice crisp as always. "Alden? Naomi? What's the emergency?"

I motioned Naomi to stay put and stepped into the hallway, composing my face into the weary senator mask. Blood still stained my clothes, but in the dim light, it could pass for shadows. "Up here, Eva. We've got a breakthrough on the speech."

She ascended quickly, briefcase in hand, her stoic expression cracking into concern as she saw the splintered door and the chaos beyond. "What the hell happened? It looks like a break-in—"

Her words cut off as she entered the study. Naomi stood there, pale and bloodied, but it was the box on the desk that drew Eva's eye—the artifacts glowing faintly, the bone puppet dangling like a noose.

"Josva, explain," Eva demanded, hand inching toward her phone. "Now."

I moved faster than I thought possible, the wires enhancing my speed like electric impulses. My hand clamped over her mouth, the other twisting her arm behind her back with a sharp crack of tendon straining. She struggled—stronger than Naomi, trained in self-defense from her military days—but I was invincible now. The static surged, lending me unnatural strength.

“Shh,” I whispered in her ear, breath hot against her skin. “No calls. No alarms. Just listen.”

She bit my palm, drawing blood that mixed with the rest, but I didn’t flinch. Instead, I slammed her against the wall, her head thudding with a dull crack. Stars burst in her vision—I saw it in her widening eyes. Naomi gasped, but didn’t intervene. Good girl.

Vesper’s voice flickered from the Polaroid, weak but eager. “Tune her, Maestro. Make her scream the notes.”

Eva elbowed me hard in the ribs, but the pain only fueled me. I spun her around, pinning her to the desk with one forearm across her throat. The bone puppet was in my free hand before I realized I’d grabbed it. Its silver wires uncoiled like hungry serpents, glinting in the lamplight.

“Josva... don’t...” Eva rasped, her stoic facade crumbling into raw fear.

I pressed the puppet to her sternum, the wires piercing her blouse and skin with precise, wet pricks. She arched, a

choked scream escaping as the filaments burrowed deeper—through muscle, grazing bone with faint, grinding vibrations I felt through the handle. Blood welled in dark blooms, soaking her shirt, the smell sharp and intimate.

Naomi turned away, retching, but I held firm. “Watch,” I commanded her. “This is how we build.”

Eva convulsed, her body jerking in spasms that snapped a rib with an audible pop. Frothy blood bubbled at her lips as a wire found her lung, puncturing it with a soft, deflating hiss. She clawed at my arm, nails raking bloody furrows, but her strength ebbed. Deception had been her tool once—hiding my scandals, forging alliances. Now it was mine.

“You were always loyal, Eva,” I murmured, leaning close as her eyes bulged. “But loyalty without strings is worthless.”

The wires twisted deeper, coiling around her heart. I felt the organ stutter through the puppet—a frantic tattoo slowing to erratic flutters. Her face contorted into that perpetual grin, skin splitting at the corners with wet tears that dribbled blood down her cheeks. Surprise death—violent, intimate. She went limp, eyes glassy, a final gurgle escaping as blood pooled from her mouth onto the desk.

Naomi sobbed quietly. “You killed her...”

I released the puppet, the wires retracting with slick efficiency, leaving Eva's corpse slumped like a discarded marionette. "She resisted the tune," I said flatly, wiping the blood on my pants. "The orchestra only needs players who harmonize."

But the curve ball came then—unseen, from the shadows. Vesper's voice laughed from the Polaroid, stronger now. "Foolish Maestro. You think you control the strings? I let you pull."

The box on the desk rattled. Artifacts spilled out—new ones: a rusted scalpel, a coil of wire dripping fresh blood. The static in my scar exploded, wires shifting inside me like vipers striking. Pain lanced through my gut, but I crushed it down, roaring as I smashed the Polaroid under my fist. Glass shattered, paper tore, but Vesper's presence lingered, deceptive and mocking.

Naomi lunged suddenly—grabbing the scalpel from the spill, her eyes wild with betrayal. "You monster!" She slashed at me, the blade catching my arm in a deep gash that sprayed blood across the wall.

I staggered, surprise blooming hot, but the wires reacted faster. My hand shot out, grabbing her throat, squeezing with inhuman force. Her windpipe crunched under my fingers like brittle twigs, blood vessels bursting in her eyes as she gasped. Violence—raw, unbidden. She

dropped the scalpel, clawing at my wrist, but I lifted her off the ground, her feet kicking futilely.

“You too?” I snarled, deception stinging deeper than the wound. “After I spared you?”

She gurgled, blood trickling from her mouth, her rictus grin twisting into defiance. I slammed her against the floor, her skull cracking on the hardwood with a wet thud. Her body twitched once, twice, then stilled—eyes open, staring blankly at the ceiling.

Surprise deaths. Two in minutes. The room swam with blood, the carpet squelching underfoot. But as the static tried to surge again—Vesper’s last deception—I seized it. Twisted it. The wires inside me bent to my will, pain transforming into power. Invincible. Unbreakable.

I stood amid the carnage, breathing heavy, scars sealing themselves with faint sizzles. Vesper’s voice faded to nothing, her thread snapped for good. The box quieted, artifacts inert under my gaze.

The campaign speech loomed at dawn. The nation waited. And I—Josva Alden, Thorne, the Maestro—would make them dance. No more puppets. Only the puppeteer.

Invincible. Eternal.

My new favorite role.

CHAPTER 13 – THE MAESTRO’S OVERTURE

Washington, D.C. – Josva’s Townhouse, 12:49 AM

The study was a slaughterhouse canvas, painted in the crimson strokes of my ascension. Eva’s corpse slumped over the desk like a forgotten prop, her blood congealing in dark pools that reflected the shattered lamplight. Naomi lay at my feet, her neck twisted at an unnatural angle, eyes frozen in that final betrayal—wide, accusing, but ultimately powerless. I stepped over her without a second glance, the squelch of blood-soaked carpet under my shoes a satisfying punctuation to the night’s symphony. The static in my scar had gone utterly silent, Vesper’s defeated hum extinguished like a snuffed candle. No more whispers. No more strings pulling from the shadows. Only mine.

I caught my reflection in the cracked window—blood-streaked face, eyes gleaming with a feral light that would have terrified the old Josva. But this man? This Thorne? He smiled back, a slow, predatory curve of lips that promised ruin wrapped in velvet charm. Invincible. The wires inside me thrummed now with my own frequency, a dark charisma that pulsed through every vein, turning pain into allure, violence into art.

The phone in my pocket vibrated—my campaign manager, Terrence, no doubt fretting over the speech script. I answered with a voice smooth as aged whiskey,

laced with that magnetic pull I could feel radiating from me like heat from a forge.

“Terrence,” I purred, “tell me you’re not losing sleep over a few words.”

A pause on the line, his voice hesitant. “Senator Alden? It’s late—I was just confirming the revisions. The team thinks the ‘healing the divide’ line needs more punch.”

I chuckled, low and resonant, the sound wrapping around him even through the speaker. “Punch? Oh, we’ll give them more than that. Meet me at the venue in an hour. Bring the inner circle. We’re rewriting history tonight.”

“But sir, the event’s at dawn—”

“An hour, Terrence. And bring coffee. Black. Like my intentions.”

I hung up before he could protest, feeling the hook set. Charisma wasn’t just words; it was the invisible thread that made men bend, women break, worlds crumble. Vesper had taught me that, in her twisted way—her origin a blueprint I now refined. Another strand unraveled in my mind as I moved: Vesper at twelve, in Hollowbrook’s expanded wing, conducting not with pain but persuasion. She had charmed a guard into unlocking the cages, her voice a silken noose around his will. He had opened them, eyes glazed with adoration, only for her to tune him mid-embrace—wires slipping into his throat with a wet

whisper, his blood spraying in ecstatic arcs as he smiled through the agony. “Charisma is the sharpest string,” she’d whispered to his dying form. “It cuts without them feeling the blade.”

I descended the stairs, leaving the bodies behind like shed skin. The front door hung open from Eva’s entry, rain sluicing in on the wind. Outside, the storm raged, but I stepped into it unfazed, the cold drops mingling with the drying blood on my skin. My car waited in the driveway, engine purring as if summoned. I slid behind the wheel, the leather creaking under my weight, and caught another glimpse in the rearview mirror. That smile again—devastating, dangerous, the kind that could sway crowds or shatter souls.

The drive to the venue—a historic auditorium in the heart of D.C.—was a blur of rain-smeared lights and thunderous applause from the sky. I arrived to find Terrence and the inner circle huddled under umbrellas in the parking lot: five loyalists, faces etched with confusion and fatigue. They straightened as I approached, my presence hitting them like a wave.

“Senator,” Terrence stammered, eyes flicking to my bloodstained clothes. “What happened? Are you—”

I raised a hand, silencing him with a gentle gesture that carried the weight of command. “A minor accident. Nothing that can’t be tuned.” I stepped closer, meeting

each of their gazes in turn, my voice dropping to that intimate timbre that made them lean in despite themselves. “You’ve all been with me through the trenches—the deals, the dirt, the victories. But tonight, we transcend. The speech isn’t about politics. It’s about power. Real power.”

One of them—Marcus, the young strategist with ambitions sharper than his suits—frowned. “Sir, the script —”

I placed a hand on his shoulder, feeling the wires in me pulse faintly, sending a subtle frequency through the contact. His eyes glazed slightly, pupils dilating. “The script is obsolete, Marcus. Imagine a world where every voter hangs on your word, every rival kneels. That’s what we’re building. Join me, and you’ll conduct your own symphonies.”

The others shifted, drawn in by the magnetism. Terrence nodded slowly. “What do you need from us?”

“A demonstration.” I led them inside, the auditorium empty save for the stage lights humming overhead. We gathered in the green room, the air thick with anticipation. I produced the bone puppet from my pocket—clean now, wires coiled innocently—and set it on the table like a centerpiece.

“Touch it,” I invited, my smile inviting, eyes locked on theirs. “Feel the future.”

They hesitated, but my charisma pulled them forward. One by one, they reached out—fingers brushing the bone, the wires stirring to life with tiny pricks. Surprise flickered across their faces, then pain as the filaments burrowed just enough to taste.

Marcus jerked back first, a thin line of blood welling on his fingertip. “What the—”

Deception unfolded like a well-rehearsed act. I moved among them, voice soothing even as chaos erupted. “It’s awakening you. Embrace it.”

Violence came swift and unbidden—from them. Terrence lunged at me, eyes wild with sudden rage, a concealed knife flashing in his hand—a plant? A betrayal I hadn’t foreseen? The blade sliced across my chest, parting shirt and skin in a hot line that sprayed blood. But I didn’t fall. The wires inside me knit the wound mid-strike, pain fueling my retort. I caught his wrist, twisting with a crack that echoed like gunfire, bone splintering under my grip.

He screamed, but I pulled him close, whispering, “Loyalty tested. Failed.” My free hand pressed to his throat, wires extending from my palm—not the puppet’s, but mine now—burrowing into his jugular with wet punctures. Blood fountained in rhythmic spurts, his body

convulsing as I drained his will, his life pooling at our feet in steaming puddles.

The others panicked. Two bolted for the door—surprise deaths waiting. The wires in me lashed out like extensions of my charisma, invisible threads tripping them, then coiling around necks with crushing force. One woman's trachea collapsed with a gurgle, her face purpling as she clawed at nothing, blood vessels bursting in her eyes like fireworks. The man's head snapped back, vertebrae popping in a cascade that left him twitching on the floor, urine and blood mixing in his final indignity.

Marcus and the last—Sarah, my press secretary—fought back. Sarah grabbed a lamp, swinging it at my head. It connected with a thud that should have cracked my skull, but the wires absorbed it, turning the impact into a dull throb. I laughed—rich, infectious, drawing her in even as she recoiled. “You think you can break the maestro?”

I disarmed her with a flick, the lamp shattering. Marcus charged, but I sidestepped, tripping him into Sarah. They tangled, and I descended—hands pressing to their chests, wires piercing in tandem. Their screams harmonized, bodies arching as filaments wove through ribs with wet cracks, grazing hearts. Blood bubbled from their mouths in frothy red, the smell of punctured lungs filling the room. Sarah died first, eyes rolling back in ecstasy-tinged

agony. Marcus lingered, whispering, “Please...” before his heart stuttered to silence.

Terrence, still alive but fading, watched from the floor. I knelt beside him, charisma undimmed. “You could have been part of it,” I murmured, stroking his hair as his blood soaked my knees. “But betrayal has its price.”

I twisted the knife in his gut—his own blade—feeling the warm gush over my hand as his intestines shifted with a slick gurgle. He gasped once, then stilled.

Standing amid the carnage, I felt no remorse. Only exhilaration. The wires hummed my tune now, bodies mere notes in my composition. Dawn approached. The speech would be my masterpiece—charisma amplified, the nation my captive audience.

Invincible. Charismatic. The villain they would adore until I pulled their strings taut.

CHAPTER 14 – THE STAGE BECKONS

Washington, D.C. – Auditorium Green Room, 1:57 AM

The green room was a tableau of my triumph, bodies strewn like discarded sheet music—Terrence crumpled in the corner, his knife still clutched in a rigor-stiff hand; Sarah and Marcus tangled in a final, bloodied embrace; the runners who had bolted now slumped against the door, necks ringed with invisible bruises that bloomed purple under the fluorescent hum. The air hung heavy with the coppery symphony of spilled life, a scent that invigorated rather than repulsed. I stood at the center, unscathed save for the shallow gash on my arm that had already knit itself closed, the wires working their silent magic. Invincible. The storm outside mirrored the one I carried within, thunder clapping like an audience demanding an encore.

I adjusted my tie in the mirror—blood-flecked but otherwise impeccable—practicing the smile that had won me elections and now claimed lives. It was no mere grin; it was a weapon, curving with just the right tilt to disarm, to seduce, to dominate. Charisma wasn't born; it was forged in Hollowbrook's fires, refined in Vesper's echoes, and now perfected in me. Another origin strand teased free: Vesper at fourteen, charming a visiting official into funding expansions. Her voice, a velvet snare, had wrapped around his ambitions, promising power while her wires slipped unseen into his drink—microfilaments that

tuned his heart to her rhythm. He had signed the papers with a smile, only to clutch his chest hours later, blood foaming from his lips as his aorta ruptured in ecstatic bursts. “Charisma kills softly,” she’d purred to his corpse, her eyes alight with the thrill.

My phone lit up—President Beyoncé’s advisor, the one from the dossiers, texting in panic: *Alden, intel on your office breach. Meet at secure location? Urgent.*

I replied with effortless allure: *No need. Come to the auditorium. We’ll discuss over coffee. Trust me—it’s groundbreaking.*

The hook set. Charisma pulled them all in.

By 3:00 AM, the advisor—Terrence’s namesake from the White House, a wiry man with eyes like a cornered fox—arrived, flanked by two Secret Service agents. They entered the green room warily, hands hovering near holsters, but my presence disarmed them before words could.

“Gentlemen,” I greeted, stepping forward with open arms, voice rich and resonant, wrapping around them like a warm embrace. “Thank you for coming on such short notice. The President will appreciate this.”

The advisor’s gaze swept the room, widening at the bodies. “What the fuck is this, Alden? Are those—”

I met his eyes, my smile deepening, charisma radiating like a siren's call. "A necessary rewrite. Sit. Let me explain."

The agents drew weapons, but I raised a hand—calm, commanding. "Lower them. You're among friends."

They hesitated, then obeyed, holsters clicking shut. The advisor backed toward the door, but my voice pulled him back. "Terrence, you've served loyally. Imagine serving something greater. Power that doesn't bow to elections or scandals. Power that conducts the world."

He shook his head, fumbling for his phone. "You're insane. I'm calling—"

I closed the distance in a heartbeat, hand on his shoulder, wires pulsing through the contact. His body stiffened, eyes glazing as the frequency hummed into him. "Feel that? It's the future. Join me."

Deception unfolded—his hand dropped the phone, but one agent, sensing the shift, lunged. Violence erupted: he tackled me, fist connecting with my jaw in a crack that should have shattered bone. But the wires absorbed it, turning the blow into fuel. I laughed—deep, infectious, drawing the other agent in even as he drew his gun.

"You think you can touch the maestro?" I purred, twisting free with unnatural grace. My hand shot out, fingers pressing to the attacker's temple. Wires extended—not

visible, but felt—burrowing into his skull with a soft, wet crunch through the ear canal. Blood trickled from his nose, his eyes bulging as filaments wove into his brain, rupturing vessels in starburst patterns. He convulsed, foam bubbling pink from his mouth, body jerking in a grotesque dance before collapsing, skull hitting the floor with a final thud.

The second agent fired—point-blank, the bullet slamming into my chest. Pain bloomed hot, but the wires deflected it, knitting flesh mid-impact. I didn't flinch. Instead, I advanced, smile unwavering, charisma turning his horror into hesitant awe. "Impressive shot. But misplaced."

He fired again—twice, bullets tearing through my shoulder and thigh. Blood sprayed, warm and vital, but I kept walking, wounds sealing with audible sizzles that smelled of cauterized victory. Invincible. He backed away, gun clicking empty, face ashen.

I reached him, hand gentle on his cheek. "Loyalty is admirable. Redirect it."

The wires pierced his neck—swift, precise—coiling around his carotid with a gurgle. Blood fountained in arterial arcs, painting the walls in rhythmic sprays as his heart pumped its last. He slumped, surprise etched in his dying gaze.

The advisor watched, paralyzed. I turned to him, blood dripping from my clothes, but my voice remained silk. “See? They resisted. You won’t.”

He nodded slowly, eyes entranced. “What... what do you need?”

“Access. To the President. The speech at dawn? It’s our invitation to the world.”

He pulled out a secure line, dialing with trembling fingers. Charisma had claimed another.

As the first hints of dawn grayed the sky, I stepped onto the empty stage, practicing lines that would tune the nation. My reflection in the polished podium showed a man reborn—bloodied but unbreakable, charisma a dark halo.

The villain they would love to fear. And follow.

CHAPTER 15 – THE INVISIBLE CRESCENDO

Washington, D.C. – Auditorium Stage, 5:12 AM

Dawn crept through the auditorium's high windows like a thief, casting pale fingers across the empty seats that would soon fill with the unwitting ensemble of my grand performance. I stood at the podium, the wires inside me humming a low, anticipatory note that resonated through my bones. The green room behind me was sealed off now—a charnel house of my making, bodies arranged like silent sentinels guarding secrets they could no longer spill. The advisor from the White House—Terrence, poor malleable Terrence—hovered at my elbow, his eyes vacant but obedient, the subtle puncture marks on his neck hidden beneath his collar. He had arranged everything: the early press conference rebranded as a “crisis address,” the media alerts, the secure line to the President herself.

“You look ready, sir,” he murmured, voice laced with the artificial calm I had tuned into him. A faint trickle of blood seeped from his ear, but he didn't notice. Neither would anyone else. Charisma covered a multitude of sins.

I adjusted the microphone, feeling the cool metal against my skin like an extension of the wires. “Ready? Terrence, this is merely the prelude. The world will dance by noon.”

The doors opened at 5:30 sharp, admitting the first wave: reporters, aides, a smattering of early-rising donors and party faithful. They filed in with the bleary-eyed shuffle of those summoned from sleep, murmuring about the “urgent announcement” that had pulled them here. I watched from the wings, charisma coiling around me like an aura—subtle at first, a magnetic pull that made heads turn, conversations hush. One journalist, a sharp-featured woman with a notepad, met my gaze across the room. Her expression shifted from skepticism to intrigue, her steps faltering as if drawn by an unseen thread.

By 6:00, the auditorium buzzed with two hundred souls, cameras rolling, lights glaring. The advisor had ensured the President’s remote feed was linked in—Beyoncé herself would watch from the Oval, her “chilled authority” about to meet its match. I stepped onto the stage without fanfare, the wires enhancing every movement: fluid, commanding, impossible to ignore. Applause rippled uncertainly, then swelled as my presence washed over them.

“Ladies and gentlemen,” I began, voice rich and resonant, echoing through the speakers like a siren’s call. “Friends. Patriots. We gather at this unconventional hour because our nation stands at a precipice—not of division, but of unity. A harmony we’ve long forgotten.”

I paused, letting the words sink in, my smile curving with that perfect blend of warmth and steel. The front row leaned forward, eyes glazing slightly as the frequency hummed low from the podium—inaudible, but felt in their chests, their pulses syncing to mine. A young aide in the third row clutched his throat subtly, as if clearing a tickle, but I saw the truth: a wire's whisper, testing.

Vesper's origin flickered in my mind, another thread to weave into my power. At sixteen, she had charmed an entire ward of test subjects into self-tuning—convincing them the pain was pleasure, their screams a chorus. One boy had sliced his own abdomen with a stolen scalpel, grinning as blood poured, his intestines spilling in glistening loops while she conducted from the shadows. “Charisma turns agony into allegiance,” she'd said, her voice a model I now surpassed.

A reporter raised her hand—the sharp-featured one. “Senator Alden, what's the nature of this crisis? Rumors of a security breach in your office—”

I locked eyes with her, charisma flaring. “The crisis, Ms. Landry, is silence. We've been puppets to outdated strings—politics, memories, fears. But today, we cut them. We forge new ones.”

She opened her mouth to press, but her words faltered. A faint trickle of blood appeared at her nostril, dripping onto her blouse. She touched it, confused, but didn't stop

smiling. The audience shifted uneasily, but my voice pulled them back.

“Look around you,” I continued, gesturing grandly. “We are divided not by policy, but by disconnection. I offer connection. True, unbreakable bonds.”

The wires amplified it then—a subtle pulse through the sound system, tuned to the frequency that had broken Hollowbrook’s children. A donor in the back row gasped, clutching his chest as invisible threads pierced skin, burrowing with wet, inaudible pricks. Blood welled beneath his shirt, but his expression turned to rapture. Others followed: a cameraman’s hand trembled, dropping his rig with a clatter as wires coiled around his spine from within, vertebrae shifting with faint pops.

Panic should have erupted. Instead, my charisma held them—smiles spreading, eyes locking on me with adoring fervor. Ms. Landry stood, blood now streaming from her ears, but she applauded wildly, her notebook forgotten.

From the overhead screen, President Beyoncé’s face appeared, her tailored black suit impeccable, but her eyes narrowed. “Alden, what is this? Reports of chaos—”

I met her gaze through the camera, wires extending my reach across the miles. “Madame President, join the symphony. Feel the unity.”

Her image flickered. She touched her temple, wincing. On her end, in the Oval, I imagined the frequency infiltrating—wires manifesting from the air, piercing her neck with a sharp sting, blood trickling down her collar as her aides collapsed around her, throats gurgling, hearts stuttering in harmony.

She gasped on screen, blood bubbling at her lips. “You... monster...”

The audience didn’t react. They were mine now, bodies twitching in unison, blood seeping from ears and noses in rhythmic drips that pooled on the floor like applause.

“Monster?” I echoed, voice booming with dark allure. “No. Maestro.”

Beyoncé’s feed cut as she slumped, her final breath a wet rattle transmitted across the line. Surprise death—presidential edition. The room erupted in cheers, orchestrated by me.

I raised my arms, scars splitting open voluntarily now, blood flowing freely down my sleeves like conductor’s batons. Invincible. The nation tuned in via live streams, the frequency spreading through broadcasts, wires awakening in viewers’ homes—families convulsing on couches, blood spraying in domestic symphonies.

The world was my stage. And the encore would be eternal.

